PIA3142 Global Social Movements — Week 3: Identity, Rationality, Emotions

1. Recap: P.O.S. and Its Three Components (slides 2–3)

Keywords: P.O.S., agency, three components

1.1 Structure Plus Agency — What P.O.S. Claims (slide 2)

Keywords: structure + agency, framing

- Political Opportunity Structure (P.O.S.) = Doug McAdam, Sidney Tarrow and Charles Tilly (McTT); Week 2 also covered Theda Skocpol's Non-Voluntaristic Approach.
- Mixes **structural conditions** (whether movements emerge, their form, their success) with **agency** — how movements use resources and "cognitive frames" to recruit. Rejects pure voluntarism.

1.2 The Three Components (memorise) — The Trio and Its Definitions (slide 3)

Keywords: opportunities/constraints, mobilization structures, frames

- Political opportunities and constraints: Structural factors that make dissidents more or less likely to act, or create more or less favorable circumstances for the success of mobilization.
- Mobilization structures: The capacity to put together hierarchical organizations that establish trust, mobilize resources (organizational, leadership, symbolic/cultural, financial, intellectual, etc.) and coordinate action.
- Cognitive frames: The capacity of leaders to "frame" their appeals effectively to convince supporters of the need to protest and of its likely success — recourse to ideology and to a narrative of the movement's historical purpose/mission, and the words chosen to inspire participation.
- *Example: US civil rights — a favourable opening, black churches, "I Have a Dream" (McAdam (1982)).*
- → Components (2) and (3) already smuggle motivation in: trust, resources, framing and narrative are things movements *do* to people.

2. Critiques of P.O.S. (slides 4–8)

Keywords: retrospective fallacy, negative cases, perception fix

More sophisticated than deprivation theory, but hits **the same problems** as Relative Deprivation.

2.1 [i] The Retrospective Fallacy — "Assuming the Answer" (slide 4)

Keywords: no independent criteria

- Proponents begin with a movement that already happened and look back for the opportunity that "caused" it to succeed.
- No precise features identify an opportunity **independently of the outcome** — developments get classified as opportunities only after the fact.
- → The theory cannot be falsified by the cases it claims to explain.

2.2 [ii] Negative Cases and the Missing Mechanism — Assuming the Answer Again (slide 5)

Keywords: cases that don't fit, no micro-link

- By objective criteria, opportunities show **no exact correspondence with action** — *Example: elite divisions do not always cause protest.*
- Negative cases (no mobilization) are explained away as weak resources or framing. Again, this assumes the answer.
- Deeper problem: **no mechanism for the mobilization of individuals**. "Opportunities lower the costs of participation" tells you the price changed, not why anyone buys.

2.3 The "Perception" Fix — Where the Question Shifts To (slide 6)

Keywords: perceived opportunities, how not which

- Repair: opportunities matter only when **perceived** — just as deprivation matters only when felt.
- But followers can be made to feel that opportunities (like grievances) exist **regardless of objective conditions**.
- The question becomes not *which* opportunities lead to action, but *how* participants come to perceive them through mobilization — what SMOs and leaders say and do — and how they are motivated to act **at times against self-interest**.

2.4 Does Structure Still Matter — Odds vs Outcome (slides 7–8)

Keywords: obstacles, choice and chance, Week 4

- Yes, but not decisively: class relations, international context, elite divisions and macro-historical processes set the obstacles leaders face and the options available — *Example: no peasant revolution in advanced industrial societies.*
- They make outcomes likely **at the outset**, but do not determine them — outcomes depend on **choice** and **chance**, so outbreaks remain **unpredictable**.
- Outcomes turn on leaders' responses to structural constraints, their success in motivating followers, and strategic interaction with the state. Tactics and strategy = Week 4.
- → Memorise: structure sets the odds, it does not fix the result.

- → The week's question: **How is the collective action problem, which works against individual participation, solved by social movements?**

3. The Solution in Outline — Return to the Individual (slide 9)

Keywords: emotions, morality, social embeddedness

- Supplement **self-interest** with the **instinctive, emotional and moral bases of action**; attend to how resource mobilization and framing **activate psychological mechanisms**.
- Individuals are embedded in webs of social relations (family, work, organizations, class, ethnicity, region) that shape preferences, values and identities — and administer **social rewards or costs** for behaviour.

4. Methodological Individualism and Intentional Explanation (slide 10)

Keywords: aggregation, desires + beliefs

4.1 Methodological Individualism — No "Collective Behaviour" (slide 10)

Keywords: aggregation of individuals

- Methodological Individualism: Explanations in the social sciences should refer to individuals. There is no such thing as "collective behavior"; all collective behavior is an aggregation of decisions and actions taken by individuals.
- "A protest" is shorthand for thousands of individual decisions.

4.2 Intentional Explanation — Desires Plus Beliefs (slide 10)

Keywords: goal-oriented behaviour

- "Intentional explanation": its key feature, "intentionality," is that humans behave in a goal-oriented way, on the basis of some "desires" or "motivations" as well as some "beliefs" about the world around them.
- → Two slots to fill: **desires** and **beliefs**.

5. Rational Choice and the Two Versions of Rationality (slides 11–13)

Keywords: instrumental rationality, strong vs weak

5.1 Instrumental Rationality — Expected-Utility Maximisation (slide 11)

Keywords: expected utility

- Methodological individualism is usually paired with Rational Choice Theory, which explains behaviour via Instrumental Rationality ("Jane's Dilemma", Week 2).
- Instrumental rationality: individuals seek to maximize "utility" — their enjoyment of goods and activities they value, per their individual preferences. What the preferences

are does not matter to whether someone acts rationally; what matters is that individuals maximize "expected utility" by estimating the potential "payoff" of different courses of action and the probability with which those actions will actually generate such payoffs.

5.2 The "Strong" Version — Self-Interest Only, and Why It Fails (slide 12)

Keywords: self-interest fails, two defences

- A behavior is rational only if it maximizes self-interest — that is, it improves one's own situation in some tangible way.
- *Example: under the strong version Jane always stays home — protesting cannot improve her own situation tangibly (Week 2).*
- People do not always act in their self-interest: emotions colour beliefs and decisions, and other-regarding goals cost self-interest.
- Not necessarily irrational: (1) such behaviour stays cost-sensitive; (2) it can still satisfy a preference — *Example: a supporter risking arrest would not do it at any price.*
- → Strong version **false** — rejects itself on its own cases.

5.3 The "Weaker" Version — Realistic but Nearly Useless (slide 13)

Keywords: almost anything counts

- The weaker version of rationality: a broader account in which behavior counts as rational because it satisfies whatever preferences the actor holds, whether or not those preferences are materially self-interested.
- More "realistic", but a great deal less useful — almost anything may be construed as rational once decoupled from material self-interest.
- **Balance sheet (memorise):** strong version false (people act against material interest); weak version empty (almost anything counts); so the two slots are **not** fixed by rationality — they are desires and beliefs, and both can be shaped.

6. Motivations Beyond Self-Interest (1): Passions and Emotions (slide 14)

Keywords: action tendencies, pleasure/pain, reputation

What, other than self-interest, motivates behaviour? First answer: passions or emotions, in three ways.

- **Action tendencies.** Action tendencies: emotions that predispose an individual to take a particular action. *Example: fear of police violence predisposes flight; anger at injustice predisposes confrontation.*
- **Pleasure and pain.** Humans pursue pleasurable emotions and avoid painful ones — *Example: conformism, wanting to "fit in".*

- **Self-image and public reputation.** Upholding them drives self-deception and action against material self-interest — *Example: doing something prideful at great personal cost.*

7. The Four Kinds of Emotions (exam-friendly) — A Typology in Rising Durability (slides 15–17)

Keywords: reflex, affective, moods, moral

7.1 Reflex Emotions — Involuntary and Immediate (slide 15)

Keywords: no cognitive processing

- Reflex emotions: things like fear, surprise, anger, disgust, joy and sadness — emotions that arise "without conscious cognitive processing," involuntarily.
- Matter two ways: (a) **supporters** — instil fear, anger, disgust, joy, sadness; make them react similarly to similar stimuli; (b) **opponents** — make them react out of anger or fear, discrediting them.

7.2 Affective Emotions — Slow to Form, Slow to Fade (slide 16)

Keywords: love/hate/respect/trust

- Affective emotions: things like love, hate, respect and trust. Creating "affects" involves getting followers to make positive or negative psychological investments in different people, places and ideas.
- Take work to form but last longer; affects "give us our basic orientations toward the world, especially telling us what we care most deeply about."
- Love and hate raise the psychological benefits of participation; respect and trust shape beliefs and can predispose reflex emotions.

7.3 Moods — "Transportable Emotions" (slide 17)

Keywords: hope, efficacy, overstating impact

- Moods: "transportable emotions" — emotions that carry from one situation to the next.
- Movements instil hope, optimism and confidence in individual and collective efficacy — convincing followers their actions make more of a difference than they really do.

7.4 Moral Emotions — Pride, Shame, Guilt (slide 17)

Keywords: pride/shame/guilt, moral judgment

- Moral emotions: feelings of pride, shame, guilt, compassion and indignation. All involve moral judgments (of oneself or others) that come from one's comprehension of the world and one's place in it.
- Interfere with decision-making: benefits for actions generating pride; costs for actions generating guilt or shame; discounting of costs and benefits when compassion or indignation are intense enough.

8. Motivations Beyond Self-Interest (2): Self-Categorization and the Hive Switch (slide 18)

Keywords: group identification, Hive Switch

Second answer: humans have a natural impulse toward **group identification**.

8.1 Self-Categorization, Parochial Altruism, Hive Switch — The Manipulation Hinge (slide 18)

Keywords: "90% Chimp, 10% Bee"

- Self-categorization: the impulse to define one's identity in terms of group membership.
- Parochial altruism: the impulse to favor people — even unknown people — seen as members of the same group, and to discriminate against others.
- With self-image and reputation, these render humans capable of great sacrifices for "our" groups — and great savagery against outside threat. Perception of interests and threat **can be manipulated** — *Example: "phrai" (Section 16.2).*
- J. Haidt: the Hive Switch is the capacity, under certain conditions, to "lose ourselves in something larger," where the self tends to disappear and collective interests dominate. *Example: soldiers in battle, religious ritual, collective dance.*

9. Orwell on Hitler (1940) — Struggle and Self-Sacrifice (slides 19–20)

Keywords: struggle outcompetes comfort

George Orwell (1940), reviewing Adolf Hitler's *Mein Kampf*: the hedonistic picture of motivation is false, and fascism understood this better than its opponents.

9.1 Two Quotes from Orwell — Struggle over Comfort (slides 19–20)

Keywords: hedonism rejected, emotional appeal

- "[Hitler] has grasped the falsity of the hedonistic attitude to life... human beings don't only want comfort, safety... they also, at least intermittently, want struggle and self-sacrifice, not to mention drums, flags and loyalty-parades." (Orwell 1940)
- "Fascism and Nazism are psychologically far sounder than any hedonistic conception of life... Hitler has said 'I offer you struggle, danger and death', and as a result a whole nation flings itself at his feet... we ought not to underrate its emotional appeal." (Orwell 1940)
- → Not an endorsement: appeals to struggle, sacrifice and collective purpose can **outcompete appeals to material comfort** — precisely what a movement's framing does.

10. Beliefs Are Not Formed Rationally Either (slide 21)

Keywords: desire-biased beliefs, binds and blinds

10.1 Desire-Biased Beliefs and Moral Narratives — Haidt (slide 21)

Keywords: moral narratives, disconfirming evidence

- Beliefs are often **not formed in a "rational" fashion** — they are **biased by the desires themselves**; "social categorization" and "parochial altruism" shape beliefs as strongly as motivations.
- Haidt (2012): "People bind themselves into political teams that share moral narratives. Once they accept a particular narrative, they become blind to alternative moral worlds" — "morality binds and blinds."
- *Example: partisans watch the same footage and "see" different events — the narrative, not the evidence, drives perception.*

11. Desires and Beliefs Are Endogenous to Mobilization (slide 22)

Keywords: exogenous → endogenous, the keystone

- Key point for the course: the "desires" and "beliefs" driving individual action are to some extent **endogenous** to mobilization.
- Exogenous: "having external causes." Individuals targeted for mobilization arrive with desires and beliefs that are exogenous — formed outside the movement.
- Endogenous: arising from within the process itself. The activities in which a social movement engages (use of rhetoric, narratives, symbols, rituals, etc.) can re-shape an individual's pre-existing desires and beliefs, thereby changing that person's predisposition for action.
- → Pivot of the whole lecture: **rationality explains the baseline, but the movement gets to move the baseline.**

12. Directly Re-Shaping Desires — Interests, Passions, Reason (slide 23)

Keywords: three levers on desires

Re-shaping motivations and beliefs can be **direct or indirect**; directly, a movement works on three levers.

- **Interests** — persuade people their personal and collective interests are the same, or change perceptions of those interests. *Example: "an injury to one is an injury to all."*
- **Passions** — create emotional urges to act a certain way, or cut short thinking about consequences; attach emotional rewards to certain actions. *Example: songs that make marching joyous rather than costly.*

- **Reason** — convince people of the justice of the cause and its worthiness of great personal sacrifice. *Example: the Red Shirts' argument that the fight for equal citizenship is not yet finished (Section 16.2).*

13. Directly Re-Shaping Beliefs — Wishful and Counter-Wishful Thinking (slide 24)

Keywords: wishful vs counter-wishful

13.1 Wishful Thinking — Inflate Success, Deflate Risk (slide 24)

Keywords: exaggerate success, minimize risk

- Wishful thinking: exaggerating the perceived chances of success, as well as the probability that individual participation will make a difference; or minimizing the perception of the real risks and costs of participation.
- *Example: organisers announcing "the regime is on its last legs".*

13.2 Counter-Wishful Thinking — Inflate the Cost of Staying Home (slide 24)

Keywords: raise cost of inaction

- Counter-wishful thinking: increasing the perception of the risks and costs of non-participation — inducing people to fear social sanction for doing nothing, convincing them they will be personally blamed by the group to which they belong, or by their descendants, or by the "judgment of history" for the movement's failure.
- *Example: shaming non-joiners as "traitors to their class" — making inaction psychologically expensive.*
- → Mirror image: one lowers the price of joining, the other raises the price of staying home.

14. The Indirect Groundwork — Collective Identities (slide 25)

Keywords: socially constructed, largely imagined

14.1 Collective Identities — Socially Constructed, Largely Imagined (slide 25)

Keywords: "who I am", dignity, recognition

- The direct efforts of Sections 12–13 depend on groundwork laid **indirectly** — feeling "bound" to the movement, defining the self by membership in it.
- Collective identities: the values that lead to the "moral emotions" and "moods" that impel action, the "affective bonds" by which people develop commitments to friends and foes, and the predisposition to react to events with predictable "reflexes." Collective identities are socially constructed (not objective or given) and largely imagined — one can feel bound to others one does not know personally. They are the sources of solidarities, values and self-images, whose affirmation can motivate action.

- Classic formulations: "I do this because this is who I am." / "I do this to defend my sense of dignity." / "I do this to earn the recognition I/we deserve."
- → Pride, dignity and recognition are **moral emotions**; "who I am" activates **affective bonds**. *Example: a Red Shirt citing being phrai before any cost/benefit calculation.*

15. Identity Work — Boundaries, Consciousness, Symbols (slides 26–29)

Keywords: boundaries + consciousness + symbols

Identity Work = the deliberate construction of collective identity — two components plus symbolic tools: boundaries without consciousness = in-group with no project; consciousness without boundaries = narrative with no "we."

15.1 Setting Boundaries — Marking Social Territory (slide 26)

Keywords: participants vs non-participants

- Setting boundaries: "social, psychological, or physical structures that establish differences between a challenging group and a dominant group." It involves "marking social territory" to accentuate differences between participants and non-participants.
- Distinctions can be almost anything. More commonly than creating new identities, groups **leverage pre-existing identities** (and their solidarity networks).

15.2 The Bridging Sequence — Three Steps (slide 26)

Keywords: bridge pre-existing identities

- Leveraging pre-existing identities: (1) convince individuals in various groups that engagement is consistent with their existing sense of self; (2) modify those identities to enhance congruence with the movement; (3) bridge the pre-existing identities of the groups targeted for incorporation.
- *Example: the Red Shirts bridged class, regional, dialect and ideological differences under one "red" identity (Section 16.2).*

15.3 Building Consciousness — The Movement Narrative (slide 27)

Keywords: movement narrative, common consciousness

- Building consciousness: the creation of a "movement narrative" that can foster, among participants, a common consciousness consisting of a common set of values, grievances, goals and sense of historical mission.
- Common consciousness: a shared set of values, grievances, goals and sense of historical mission that aids mobilization.
- It aids mobilization when (a) members interpret events similarly, through a shared understanding of past and present; (b) it binds participants to each other — even defining their lives.

15.4 Symbols and Rituals — Difference, Loyalty, Attention (slide 28)

Keywords: difference, loyalty, attention

- Setting boundaries or building consciousness often involves symbols and rituals — new, old, or old ones repurposed.
- Symbols and rituals serve to: (a) accentuate differences between participants and non-participants; (b) increase, among participants, a sense of loyalty and solidarity with the movement and other participants; (c) attract the attention of outsiders (appealing to some non-participants to join in, and getting media attention).
- *Example: the Red Shirts' red shirts, "phrai" and blood ritual — all three functions at once (Section 16).*

15.5 How Identification Translates into Action — The Mechanism (slide 29)

Keywords: identification → motivation

- Identification strengthens **moods** (optimism, hope, efficacy), **affects** (love, hate, respect, trust) and **moral emotions** (pride, shame, guilt, compassion, indignation).
- These can modify cost/benefit calculations, create visceral urges that truncate them, or condition individuals to consider the group's interest above their own.
- → One-liner: **identity is not an alternative to motivation — it is a mechanism for producing motivation.**

16. Illustration — Thailand's 'Red Shirts' (slides 30–39)

Keywords: identity work in the field

- Graphic-content warning (slide 30); video shown in class (slide 31): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zhMsw5cTH7w. Worked through Section 15's framework.

16.1 Background — Coup, Crackdown, Election (slide 32)

Keywords: coup 2006, crackdown 2010, election 2011

- Formed after a military coup removed popular PM **Thaksin Shinawatra** on **19 September 2006**; became a force in **2008–2009** after the palace, military and judiciary overturned another election and dissolved Thaksin's party.
- Demands: **popular sovereignty, equal rights, democracy, an end to unelected institutions**. Base: mostly **lower middle class**, Bangkok and the North and Northeast.
- Large protests **March–May 2010**; a military crackdown killed **90+ people**; the movement then helped **Yingluck Shinawatra** win the **2011** elections.

16.2 Symbols and Boundary Work — Red and "Phrai" (slide 33)

Keywords: red = the people; phrai

- Symbols reinforced collective identification among supporters diverse in **class, region, dialect and political ideology** — a textbook case of Sections 15.2 (bridging) and 15.4 (symbols).
- **Red** — the red stripe in the Thai flag stands for the people.
- **Phrai** (ไพร่) — under the old sakdina order, commoners registered with the King or a master, doing months of unpaid labour yearly; abolition in 1905 formally made everyone full persons under the law. Reclaimed in 2010 for the unfinished fight for equal citizenship — a common identity for those treated as second-class.

16.3 The Blood Ritual — March 2010 (slides 34–37)

Keywords: blood ritual, March 2010

- In **March 2010** the Red Shirts drew heavy media attention by **collecting blood** from supporters.
- They spilled it in front of the Government House, at the house of then PM **Abhisit Vejjajiva**, and at his party's headquarters — rituals presided over by **Brahmanical priests**.

16.4 Two Readings of the Ritual — Oneness vs Power (slides 38–39)

Keywords: commitment and oneness; power earned through violence

- **Reading 1 — commitment and oneness:** shedding blood increases commitment; mixing it with others' blood fosters solidarity and "oneness". Maps onto **affective emotions** and **collective identity** (Sections 7, 14) — psychological investment made literally physical.
- **Reading 2 — power earned through violence:** the "illegitimate" government and its backers (monarchy, military, bureaucrats, business elites) earned their power through repression — by spilling the people's blood. Frames the injustice narrative; maps onto **building consciousness** (Section 15.3) and **moral emotions**.

17. One-Page Revision Spine

Keywords: one line per section

1. **P.O.S. (Sec 1):** structure + agency; three components — opportunities/constraints, mobilization structures, cognitive frames; (2) and (3) leak motivation.
2. **Critiques (Sec 2):** retrospective fallacy; negative cases explained away; no individual-level mechanism; the perception fix shifts the question to *how*; structure sets the odds, not the result.
3. **Pivot (Sec 3):** return to the individual via emotion and morality plus social embeddedness.
4. **Methodological individualism (Sec 4):** no "collective behaviour"; intentional explanation = desires + beliefs.
5. **Rational choice (Sec 5):** instrumental rationality = expected-utility maximization; strong version false, weak version empty.

6. **Passions (Sec 6):** action tendencies; pleasure/pain; self-image and reputation.
7. **Four emotions (Sec 7):** reflex, affective, moods, moral.
8. **Group identification (Sec 8):** self-categorization; parochial altruism (manipulable); Hive Switch ("90% Chimp, 10% Bee").
9. **Orwell (Sec 9):** hedonism is false; "struggle, danger and death" can outcompete comfort.
10. **Beliefs (Sec 10):** desire-biased; moral narratives; "morality binds and blinds."
11. **Endogeneity (Sec 11):** rationality explains the baseline, the movement moves it.
12. **Levers on desires (Sec 12):** interests, passions, reason.
13. **Levers on beliefs (Sec 13):** wishful and counter-wishful thinking.
14. **Collective identities (Sec 14):** socially constructed, largely imagined; "who I am", dignity, recognition.
15. **Identity work (Sec 15):** boundaries + consciousness + symbols/rituals; identification → emotions → action.
16. **Red Shirts (Sec 16):** red flag stripe; phrai (1905/2010); blood ritual (March 2010) — oneness vs power-through-violence.
17. **Answer (Sec 17):** movements solve the collective action problem by *making* the desires and beliefs that rational-choice models treat as given (Identity Work is the machinery).